them about the geography, history and economy of the empire. True, many people across the empire did share some cultural ideas, such as a strong belief in the superiority of Roman civilisation over the barbarians. These shared cultural beliefs were crucial in preserving order and holding the empire together. But their political implications were far from clear, and in times of crisis there was no possibility of holding a public conversation about what should be done.

How could Syrian merchants, British shepherds and Egyptian villagers converse about the ongoing wars in the Middle East or about the immigration crisis brewing along the Danube? The lack of a meaningful public conversation was not the fault of Augustus, Nero, Caracalla or any of the other emperors. They didn't sabotage Roman democracy. Given the size of the empire and the available information technology, democracy was simply unworkable. This was acknowledged already by ancient philosophers like Plato and Aristotle, who argued that democracy can work only in small-scale city-states.[31]

If the absence of Roman democracy had merely been the fault of particular autocrats, we should have at least seen large-scale democracies flourishing in other places, like in Sassanian Persia, Gupta India or Han China. But prior to the development of modern information technology, there are no examples of large-scale democracies anywhere.

It should be stressed that in many large-scale autocracies local affairs were often managed democratically. The Roman emperor didn't have the information needed to micromanage hundreds of cities across the empire, whereas local citizens in each city could continue to hold a meaningful conversation about municipal politics. Consequently, long after the Roman Empire became an autocracy, many of its cities continued to be governed by local assemblies and elected officials. At a time when elections to the consulship in Rome became ceremonial affairs, elections to municipal offices in small cities like Pompeii were hotly contested.

Pompeii was destroyed in the eruption of Vesuvius in 79 CE, during the reign of the emperor Titus. Archaeologists uncovered about fifteen hundred graffiti concerned with various local election campaigns. One coveted office was that of the city's aedile – the magistrate in charge of maintaining the city's infrastructure and public buildings.[32] Lucretius Fronto's supporters drew the graffiti 'If honest living is thought to be any recommendation, then Lucretius Fronto is worthy of being elected.' One of